Did I get the cash-for-votes sting horribly wrong? Should we have simply aired what we had right away without any journalistic checks? It's a tough one to answer. Maybe I should have gone along with my original instinct, which was to simply air whatever we had on tape and let all other issues be settled subsequently. We had strong circumstantial evidence against Amar Singh even though there were still plenty of holes in the overall story that needed rigorous cross-checking.

However, it is a golden rule of journalism that bigger the story, the greater the need for vigilance. 'The publish and be damned' theory cannot allow for an incomplete investigation to be aired. I am no votary of sting journalism. A sting must only be carried out when the public interest is so great that it necessitates the use of the hidden camera. The cash-for-votes scandal did qualify by this criteria—I am proud that we were able to point the searchlight on a seamier side of Indian politics and even the courts have praised our role. Where I badly erred was in not maintaining a sufficient firewall between the BJP politicians involved in the sting and our own reporting team. We had wilfully allowed ourselves to be used by a political party in their quest for power and my constant reporter's search, indeed hunger, for a big story.

The fact is, the decision when and how to telecast a sensitive story is an editorial prerogative based on sound legal and journalistic advice. Timelines cannot be decided by political parties. Political timelines and journalistic deadlines often do not, and should not, match. I know the sting operation damaged my credibility in the eyes of many BJP supporters, and I was the target of a sustained vilification campaign based on lies and abuse. Much of it was hurtful. I was even accused of taking money from the government and the likes of Amar Singh. Delhi can be a cruel city—even so-called friends here will look to find ways to bring you down. The cash-for-votes scandal left me scarred and shaken. I realized that in a surcharged political atmosphere, journalists are better off not getting entangled in murky dealings where the political stakes are blood-curdlingly high.

While I introspected, Advani thought that his chance to topple the government had come and gone. Now, his prime ministerial ambitions were